Dealing with undefined properties

Suppose the `views` object doesn't yet have any properties. If there's a page called *donatello* that receives a view, how do you increment a `donatello` property that doesn't exist? The long way to do it is to first use the existential operator to see if it exists, and then initialize it if it doesn't:

```
if !views['donatello']?
  views['donatello'] = 1
```

This is a common pattern, so there's a shorter version of it called *existential assignment*. Put an existential operator in front of the assignment operator:

```
views['donatello'] ?= 0
```

You'll notice that the `viewsIncrement` function takes the name of the property as the argument `key`, which it uses as the property name. The specific case of `donatello` is then generalized:

```
views[key] =? 0
```

There's one other foreign word, though; what does that `own` keyword in listing 4.5 do?

Own properties

The `total` function adds an `own` to the comprehension, immediately after the `for` keyword:

```
for own url, count of views
```

Objects can get properties that weren't defined directly on them but somewhere else on the prototype chain. The prototype chain is described later in this chapter, but for now, be mindful that when an object is used as a key-value store, the comprehensions in that object should always include the `own` keyword.

TIP